

Howard Stringer

The CEO of Sony lets it slip that his company will be making image sensors for Apple's iPhone 5

A city called Google

In an effort to suck up to Google, the city of Topeka officially changed its name to Google. Though only for a month.

it meant higher profits. Engagement is also critical to transforming customers into active advocates for brands and businesses; 79 per cent of respondents said that engaged customers will recommend products and services to others.

'The Business Case for Rich Internet Applications', a report published after extensive interviews with RIA technology providers and designers as well as clients and customers by Forrester revealed that "well-designed RIAs can produce eye popping results that can help prove the value of current investments and make the case for future RIA projects." According to the findings, "firms that measure the business impact of their RIAs say that rich applications meet or exceed their goals." Specific findings demonstrate that improved ease of use for customer facing RIAs "drives higher conversion rates and order size. More shoppers convert to buyers when they can easily trade off product

options and costs in real time. And because of increased ease of completing complex orders online, fewer customers give up." Additionally, the ability for RIAs to incorporate rich media pays dividends. "Rich media helps boost margins. RIAs not only enable better configurations, they also allow firms to embed video and other contextual help content into applications. Users who access these types of help features convert at a higher rate than those who don't."

YouTube is one of the biggest examples of the success of RIA technologies. It is increasingly delivering full length movies and live streaming events, and doing this without any issues or interruptions often requires fine control over buffering and dynamic quality control. Kuan Yong, platforms product manager for Google's YouTube, says that despite his company's efforts to make YouTube



videos run in an HTML5 player, Flash isn't going anywhere.

"Flash Player addresses these needs by letting applications manage the downloading and playback of video via Actionscript in conjunction with either HTTP or the RTMP video streaming protocol," explains Yong. "The HTML5 standard itself does not address video streaming protocols, but a number of vendors and organizations are working to improve the experience of delivering video over HTTP." YouTube also has to offer copy protection for some videos, like YouTube Rentals. The Flash Platform's RTMPE protocol is compatible with copyright protection technology, but HTML5 is not. Flash also remains the preferred option for video embedding. In conjunction with Google's decision to bake Flash support into its Android devices, Flash doesn't appear to be going anywhere anytime soon.

None the less the iPhone and iPad put Flash and any plugin based RIA application in general in a bad spotlight. Apple's side of the story is that Flash is a low performance, insecure, battery life drainer. Steve Jobs has been quoted in some articles as saying that Adobe programmers were "lazy" because they did not improve Flash. But despite its popularity this is not an issue only restricted to Flash but all plug in based RIA frameworks. Microsoft Silverlight and Java are also affected by many of the issues effecting Flash. None of these run on the iPhone or iPad today. HTML5 though is hailed as the future of the Web and RIA development. But it could take a very long time for it to be mature enough for extensive use. HTML5 is large and complex, and if we are to trust the current projections by the people working on this particular spec like Ian Hickson of Google and David Hyatt of Apple, for all parts to be finished it would be the year 2022, some 18 years after the process started in 2004.

However, some Web sites are already using if not the complete spec but a subset of HTML5. For example, YouTube and Vimeo have already rolled out use of the video element in HTML5. The working subset of HTML5 is nowhere near the



Vudu, an RIA.